

them. When mails in Outlook are opened, when documents are opened, when scripts are executed, they are scanned for viruses in Standard mode. In High-sensitivity mode, Avast! scans even files that are being copied and also all the messages in Outlook, including unopened ones. Resident Protection also provides protection for Outlook/Exchange, Instant Messaging, P2P, worms, browsing sessions, and for blocking access to specific Web pages.

VRDB (Virus Recovery DataBase), also known as the “Integrity Database,” is a unique feature in Avast! that aims to provide an additional security measure against viruses. If a virus gets into the system even after all the security measures, it is possible to repair infected files by returning them to their original state, using the VRDB.

Avast! updates its antivirus definitions automatically when connected to the Internet like in other anti-virus software, but unlike them, Avast!’s anti-virus updates are small—usually 100-250 KB. Updates are available whenever a new worm or virus is discovered. This is a boon for users who have slow Net connections. Whenever there is a new version of the program available, a popup informs you: “A new version of Avast! is available...” Downloading this will just update the program, and the entire Avast! setup is not downloaded.

Anti-virus software is benchmarked in terms of detecting capability, system resources consumed, features and added utilities, and how often the anti-virus detection files are updated. We took e-scan, which uses the Kaspersky anti-virus engine, Norton Antivirus 2007, AVG 7.5, and Avast! 4.7 to see how they fared. A folder containing 1.35 GB of assorted data was used for the test. The time required for scanning and the RAM requirement of each anti-virus was noted. The system used for the test was a P IV 3 GHz with 512 MB of RAM, an 80 GB HDD with Windows XP SP2.